MAHATMA GANDHI UNIVERSITY, KOTTAYAM

MGU-UGP (HONOURS) REGULAR EXAMINATION NOVEMBER 2025 FIRST SEMESTER

Discipline Specific Core Course (DSC) - MG1DSCHIS100 - INTRODUCING HISTORY

(2024 ADMISION ONWARDS)

Duration: 2 Hours **Maximum Marks: 70**

Part A
Short Answer Questions, Answer any 10 Questions Each Question carries 2 marks

1. History and progress [A] / [CO1] – Enlightenment understanding on history - Enlightenment thinkers saw history as a process of progress from lower to higher forms of rationality, and from oppression and superstition to liberty and happiness.

2. Differentiate between natural process and historical process. [An] / [CO3] - Natural processes are non-human influenced physical or biological changes in nature. Historical processes study past human events and social/cultural change.

3. How does K N Panikkar define culture? [U] / [CO2] – Culture constitutes the linchpin of the historical process - without understanding people's culture, one cannot make sense of history.

4. Describe the Historical Geographic Information System (HGIS). [U] / [CO4] - Historical GIS or HGIS is a highly interdisciplinary subject combining historical scholarship with expertise in using GIS. Historical Geographic Information Systems (HGIS) involves using historical geographic data, historical maps, and spatial analysis tools to visualize and study historical information.

5. What is Human Geography? [K] / [CO1] – Study of the relationship between people, their culture, social relations in the context of place and environment. The concept of space acquire distinctive meaning when geography analysed in the context of human interaction.

6. What are the limitations of Political History[U] / [CO1] – Though it is most common genre of history among public, political history is largely event oriented, person oriented and narrative in style. Problem oriented analytical understanding is somewhat absent in this type of history.

7. What is meant by 'absolute truth in history'? [U] / [CO1] – Represents the positivist craze for obtaining 'what happened actually' in the past – related to the concept of achieving absolute objectivity in historical research.

8. Explain the significance of everyday history archives. [U] / [CO5] – Significant source of information, focuses on the lives of ordinary people and examining how their daily practices, attitudes and experiences shaped and were shaped by the past.

9. *Histories of Latin and Germanic People*[K] / [CO3] – One of the early works of Leopold von Ranke, which attracted considerable fame for him– Ranke made use of the primary sources and critiqued previous works on the subject and scrutinized the previous treatment given by the historians.

10. Explain the term 'istoria'. [K] / [CO1] - The etymological root of the word history could trace back to the Greek word *istoria (ιστορία)*. It means inquiry, investigation or learning through research

11. Explain Cartoons as Narrators of History. [U] / [CO4] – Graphic representations convey the dominant mode of thinking and counter hegemonic enjoyment to that – Cartoons are powerful representations of social critique and everyday life of the people.

12. Discuss the concept of "prosthetic memory" in the context of Nora's argument on new archives [U] / [CO4] – It is the memory created through museums and archives – Norra dismissed it as an artificial substitute for genuine memory, a kind of disconnected history

Part B
Short Essay Type Questions, Answer any 6 Questions Each Question carries 5 marks

13. Distinguish between Speculative and Analytic Philosophy of History. [U] / [CO1] - These are two branches of philosophy of history: speculative philosophy of history is about how historians of various periods thought about the past. Here historian speculates what happened in the past based on evidences and facts- Analytical philosophy of history is the academic study of why historians thought about their past in a certain particular manner. It enquires why historian choose a particular way of writing history or way of looking at history - The former is about the historical past, while the latter is about the discipline of history.

14. Analyse history as a reenactment of the past experience. [An] / [CO3] – British historian RG Collingwood proposed the concept of 'reenactment' – He argued that history is not merely a collection of facts or a chronological narrative, but a complex process of mental reconstruction or "reenactment" of past thoughts and experiences –It is an intellectual reimagining the cognitive landscape of a particular historical moment through contextual understanding and sophisticated hermeneutic approach to historical sources - Here historians must imaginatively recreate the mental processes and perspectives of historical actors to truly comprehend historical events.

15. Discuss the impact of modernity on the relationship between memory and history, as outlined by Pierre Nora. [U] / [CO4] – Modernity altered the society's relationship with its past – with the acceleration of history modern society moves at a pace where events are quickly historicized before they can be naturally remembered – The anxiety or the fear of disappearance led to an obsessive desire to document and preserve – Real memory and living memory, which is organic, has been disappeared and their position has been taken away by archival memory. Thus, memory has been conquered by history.

16. Examine the role of documentaries in teaching and learning of history. [An] / [CO4] – Documentaries providing visual, cinematic and polemic accounts of the past – Documentaries can illustrate abstract and complex events and data and provide direct engagement to the learner – Documentary offers first-hand accounts and make things more human oriented - It can represent a past outside the realm of political history and power politics, especially when dealing with movements of 'other than elites' – Documentaries provide an opportunity to feel the past, more empathetic and compassionate understanding of the bygone age.

17. Critically examine Carlyle's portraits of great men as the makers of history. [An] / [CO1] – Carlyle, influenced by Victorian morality treated history is the biography of great men - To Carlyle, social life is the aggregate of all individual men's lives who constitute society, and history is the essence of innumerable biographies - In his work "On Heroes, Hero Worship and the Heroic in History," Carlyle argued that universal history is the history of what men have accomplished in the world - great men worked at the bottom of history as the leaders and creators - All things accomplished in the world are the practical realization and embodiment of the thoughts of great men.

18. Historian's vision of the past is illuminated by insights into the problems of the present. Examine. [E] / [CO1] – Though history's location anchored in past, a good historian can make meaningful insights towards understanding and find answers to the problems of the present – History reveals something important but hidden in our contemporary experience – Foucault employed the concept of

genealogy to seek to show the "descent" and "emergence" of the present and its institutions – It is a method of revaluing the values of the present – It is an attempt to trace the forces that give birth to our present-day practices and to identify the power relations- One has to maintain a critical distance from the present to make such understanding.

19. Explain the significance of archives as a field of a historian. [U] / [CO5] – Dedicated spaces for the systematic collection of historical documents; collected and curated point of primary source materials- An unavoidable space for a genuine researcher - Preservation: Document conservation, preventing historical information deterioration, implementing preservation technologies, and managing environmental conditions - Organization: systematic classification, developing finding aids, creating comprehensive inventories, and establishing metadata standards - Accessibility: Research facilitation, public information management, digital access platforms and controlled research environments.

20. What is the significance of cognition in writing history? [U] / [CO3] – RG Collingwood's idea of the historian's cognition is based on the reenactment of past in historian's mind – It involves the mental reconstruction of the thought process of historical actors to understand the motives and actions – For Collingwood all history is the history of thought – He stressed on the historian's imagination: a distinct form of a priori thinking, specifically tasked with imagining the past. Historians find evidence points and carefully construct connecting threads using a priori imagination, a logical cognition.

21. Outline the biography of Marc Bloch as given by Braudel in his 'Personal Testimony'. [U] / [CO2] – One of the pioneer member of Annales movement – Son of eminent historian Gustav Bloch- exemplary career at school and collegiate education – *The Royal Touch* was one of his early seminal works– Bloch met Lucien Febvre at the University of Strasbourg – together they started Annales journal in 1929 – Bloch established as an economic historian of par excellence in France – Bloch was shot by Germans in 1944 – a historian died prematurely in the words of Febvre.

22. Summarize the possibilities and challenges offered by artificial intelligence for historian [U] / [CO4] -Possibilities: Historian can employ AI in large scale language experiments like testing hypothesis or prepare narrative, descriptive and argumentative texts on same events and analyse how it works and relationship between them – Enable historian to analyse multiple layers of information – Visualize data and can plot and compare quantitative and qualitative data and attributes together – AI filters can be used to prevent the creeping of deep fake and malicious contents that manipulate footage – AI can use in reading ancient scripts and logical prediction of missing parts - Challenges: AL models are structurally unable to point to the specific textual origin – It cannot operate within the categories of referential truths – It lacked a vertical memory - AI model's apprehension towards footnotes – Bias of the input texts used to train AI models - Commercial objectives of AI and difficulty in distinguish between truth and falsehood – Consequences of machine interaction on the social memory.

Part C

Essay Type Questions, Answer any 2 Questions, Each Question carries 10 marks

23. Can objectivity be considered the most cherished value in scientific research within the field of History? Critically examine. [An] / [CO1] – Though a cherished goal, achieving complete objectivity in historical writing is undoubtedly challenging – Positivist notion of objectivity is difficult to attain in history - History, by its nature, is a subject that cannot be unbiased, objective, or merely factual - The question of historical objectivity is closely linked with value judgment – There are many factors limiting historical objectivity including; Personal and group prejudice, conflicting historical interpretations, differences in philosophical views, value judgements and moral values, incomplete evidences etc... - Consultation of maximum possible sources, loyalty to facts, kept chauvinistic tendencies away from historical analysis etc may help in objective treatment of sources and reading - Certainly, true objectivity is not attainable, but it is nonetheless a reasonable and desirable goal for historians to strive for.

24. Analyse the development of major social science disciplines. [U] / [CO1] - Social sciences emerged as object-specific, subjective disciplines by internalizing the **cognitive modes, logical structures, and communication strategies** of scientific knowledge - The process occurred in five Western nations (**UK, France, Germany, Italy, US**) with branches becoming academic disciplines in universities by the **nineteenth century - Core Disciplines: History, Economics, Sociology, Political Science, and Anthropology** were institutionalized, especially after WWI – Disciplines linked to the State Needs: History provided historicity for nation-states, Economics (from Political Economy) met administrative needs, Sociology helped governments manage the labour movement, Anthropology emerged from colonialist expansion to study non-European societies – Following the Second World War the State-centric disciplines like **Sociology, Political Science, and Economics** became dominant, marginalizing those focused on universal values, like History.

25. Assess the impact of stereotypes about India constructed during colonial period. [E] / [CO2] – Romila Thapar discussed about how the stereotypes about India constructed by the Colonial historiography later contributed to the historical sense – Stereotype of Indians are ahistorical about their past catered to the needs of colonialism and still remain in the foundations of social consciousness and political ideology - The notion of traditional Indian society as an unchanging society and the use of the Orient vs. Occident stereotype used to create an image of Indian society without subjective freedom, property, and commercial transactions - The Aryan and non-Aryan binary imposed a racial categorization over Indian society - Another stereotype, that Indians were more spiritual than others, negated the materialist outlook Indians shared and even today Indian society treated as an abode of spirituality – Stereotype of separate nationhood on the basis of religion used to legitimize two nation theory by communalists and used to spread communal divisiveness even today.

26. Describe the salient features of digital history and how does the historians use digital history resources for the historical research. [U] / [CO4] - Digital history might be understood broadly as an approach to examining and representing the past that works with the new communication technologies of the computer, the internet, and software systems – Digital history demands huge efforts in digitization projects – It is operating in a thoroughly an interdisciplinary arena – It requires cross disciplinary conversation – Tools of cliometrics can use towards the computational calculation of historical problems – Computational mapping through GIS facilitate observation of various layers of data like demography, environmental change, reporting of special incidents or crimes – Use of translating tools to read and comprehend documents of other languages and scripts - Optical Character Recognition (OCR) tools facilitates an easy extraction of text from documents – Platforms such as Google Books and other digital archives offers digitized books - Google N-Gram Viewer enables visualization of the relative rise and fall of any word or phrase in the published record in the past two centuries – There are 3-D modelling techniques, which could build understanding of the materiality of medieval manuscripts – Digital reconstruction of monuments are possible like St. Paul's Cathedral projects – Software like ITHACA enables to read and find missing words in ancient inscriptions – Large Language Models can be used for translation, the preparation of summaries, and the arrangement of information chronologically and testing basic hypotheses, write narrative, descriptive, or argumentative texts on the same events and analyze how these different forms of writing work and the relationship between them